TIMELINE OF TROUBLE



Nov. 2018: Anju Seth, an alumna of IIM-C who taught at Virginia Tech and University of Illinois in the US, becomes the institute's first woman director

Dec. 2020: Faculty members write to Ministry of Education against her 'style of functioning', express concerns over 'state of affairs' at IIM-C

Mar. 2021: IIM-C board passes resolution against Seth, reportedly takes away her power to make appointments, take disciplinary action

Mar. 2021: Seth resigns as director, cites 'breakdown of confidence' between her, the board of governors and faculty

Aug. 2021: Uttam Kumar Sarkar, faculty member and previously dean of new initiatives and external relations, succeeds Seth



Nov. 2023: Sahadeb Sarkar is appointed director-in-charge

Aug. 2023: Uttam resigns as director, cites 'personal reasons'. It is reported, however, that he had differences with the board and was "unhappy" with board chairman Shrikrishna Kulkarni's "interference" in matters related to the institute

Jan. 2024: Sahadeb exits from the post, allegedly over a complaint of alleged sexual harassment against him

the Union ministry of education (MoE) to hold off replacements pending a revision of rules. The evolving rules, pertaining to the degree of autonomy to be apportioned between the board and the director as well as the quantum of control to be reserved for the government, framed a central dilemma.

The Indian Institutes of Management (Amendment) Act, 2023, was brought in to tweak the preceding 2017 Act on a few vital counts. All the attention, predictably, was soaked up by the clauses that declared IIMs to be 'institutions of national importance' and gave the President of India, as Visitor, the power to nominate the board chairperson, be the arbiter on the director's appointment and audit all functioning. That sparked a debate on autonomy, with the director's shrinking remit forming the centrepiece of criticism.

In an alternate reading, though, this was an overcorrection of a prior misstep. According to this, the 2017 Act had, in a well-meaning turn of policy, devolved liberal amounts of executive autonomy to the director's office, but that had ironically produced excess and overreach. Hence, the 2023 tweaks that made the board 'responsible for the general superintendence, direction and control of the affairs' and made the director the 'Chief Executive Officer', who shall 'provide leadership to the institute' and also implement 'the decisions of the board'. A balance of powers is what was intended this time, what ensued was conflict over turf—stemming from individual interpretations.

It was the tensions between Seth and Kulkarni that first brought the two offices into conflict. Sources say Seth's tenure had been controversial from the word go. Nearly 15 senior faculty members quit in the first year of her taking over. "This created some discomfort for the board, but they supported her, since it appeared she was trying to bring in reforms," claims a faculty veteran, who left the institute amidst the fracas. "Gradually, this support dwindled and the board found her behaviour 'high-handed'." Seth's resignation letter, then circulated widely in the media, cited 'legacy issues related to lack of transparency or accountability, misuse of public funds, cases of abdication of responsibility, a weak financial situation…', as among the factors driving her tough actions on campus.

A majority of the faculty wrote to the board protesting Seth's way of functioning, and, receiving no response, scaled it up to the MoE in December 2020, reveals the veteran. According to him, the MoE, too, did not give a satisfactory response, but Kulkarni was soon seen interacting directly with faculty members. "Seth was incensed. It further soured equations and she eventually quit," recalls the veteran. In 2023, when Seth's successor Uttam Sarkar quit, it was speculated that he, too, was uncomfortable with the board's alleged interventions in day-to-day operations, informed sources told INDIA TODAY. Uttam Sarkar could not be reached for a comment.

The lingering uncertainty over the director's post has impacted macro initiatives at IIM-C. The appointment of two deans has been pending owing to disagreement between the last director, Sahadeb Sarkar, and the board. In-charge director Chattopadhyay says a resolution increasing the number of deans from two to four was passed a year ago, and implementation is waiting only because the terms of two existing deans will end on April 6. On dismay over the fact that the creamy layer of the much-vaunted IIM-C faculty is lying vacant, Prof. Chattopadhyay says faculty recruitment is an ongoing and challenging process: "Like all IIMs, we have vacancies as senior professors periodically retire. Recruitment process is on and many young faculty have joined." After the dust settles, and space for introspection returns, IIM-C could form a case study in its own syllabus. ■

–with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar